FLAVOUR QUEST

Every flavour has a story.



Illustrated product direction inspired by Karnataka food culture

Product Strategy and Experience Design

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15 October 2026 | Version 1.0

An illustrated culinary discovery product that connects regional food stories with flexible, self-guided neighbourhood trails. The first proposed pilot focuses on one verified cluster in Mysuru, Karnataka.

Development stage: product definition. Research, merchant participation, routes and financial outcomes remain to be validated. Illustrations show proposed experiences, not a deployed application or a verified walking route.

01 Product direction

The decision

I am developing FLAVOUR QUEST as a mobile-first discovery product for people who want to understand a place through its food. Instead of starting with an endless list of restaurants, the experience starts with a short, curated story and a practical outing that the user can adapt.

The product connects three activities: learn something about a dish, choose an achievable local visit, and keep a personal record of the experience. Reading remains available without visiting or buying. The food passport celebrates curiosity and memory rather than money spent or quantity consumed.

The problem hypothesis

A person planning a food outing may need to reconcile recommendations, menus, opening times, walking directions and the preferences of companions. My hypothesis is that a small, coherent trail can reduce this planning work while giving regional food meaningful context. This is the starting point for discovery research, not a reported user finding.

The product promise

Help me discover a place through food without making me organise every detail myself. A successful session leaves the user with a manageable plan, an honest understanding of what is known, and a story worth remembering.

Why this territory is worth investigating

Swiggy's FY2024–25 annual report describes dining experiences alongside bookings and offers within its out-of-home business. This provides category context for digital dining discovery, but does not prove demand for FLAVOUR QUEST [1]. Karnataka Tourism identifies Mysore pak as a regional sweet associated with Karnataka and provides a useful starting reference for cultural content [2]. Neither source validates a specific route or merchant partnership.

Boundaries

The pilot will not provide delivery, take payment for restaurant meals, guarantee table availability or promise allergen safety. Users pay participating venues directly. This keeps the initial product focused on discovery and route reliability while its actual value is tested.

02 Customers and value proposition

The initial customer

My primary audience is adults planning a short food outing in an unfamiliar or underexplored part of a city. They may be local residents or visitors. They want cultural discovery within a practical time and spending limit. The first pilot will focus on independent users and pairs; live group coordination will follow only if it solves an observed problem.

Customer	Need	Value to test
Local explorer	A fresh outing without lengthy planning.	A compact trail that reveals something new.
Short-stay visitor	An understandable introduction to regional food.	Context, practical stops and flexible timing.
Small food business	Relevant visitors without disruptive administration.	Clear listings and optional measured referrals.
Local contributor	Accurate, credited representation of a food tradition.	An editorial process with attribution and correction.

Jobs to be done

When I have a free morning in a city, I want a food experience that fits my time, budget and preferences, so I can explore confidently. When I run a small eatery, I want visitors to receive accurate information about my service, so an unexpected group does not disrupt ordinary customers.

Positioning hypothesis

FLAVOUR QUEST will position itself around a complete small outing and its story. Search and map products help people locate places; this product must demonstrate additional value through curation, practical sequencing and recovery when a stop becomes unavailable. A competitor review will test that distinction before making any uniqueness claim.

Demand before expansion

The initial goal is evidence of useful outings, not a large catalogue. A single dependable trail is more valuable for validation than many attractive trails with stale information. I will not expand to another neighbourhood until the first one shows repeatable operational reliability.

03 The signature experience

A living trail

A trail combines a narrative theme, optional stops and practical constraints. Its story remains coherent when the user skips a purchase, changes a stop or finishes early. Instead of treating the outing as a rigid checklist, the experience helps the user preserve what matters: the available time, an interesting discovery and an achievable next step.

The food passport

The passport stores stories read, places the user chooses to remember and private notes. A reading badge and a self-reported visit stamp are different records. Neither is presented as a verified purchase. Merchant-confirmed referrals, if introduced, will have a separate status and will not determine access to cultural content.

The recovery experience

If a shop closes or a dish is unavailable, the user can replace the stop from a curated set, continue with fewer stops, or switch to reading mode. The system explains the effect on the plan before applying it. It never silently substitutes a venue or changes a dietary preference.

Experience principles

Principle	Product consequence
Curiosity before consumption	No food-volume targets, purchase streaks or penalty for skipping.
Culture with attribution	Sources, contributor credits and correction routes accompany stories.
Honest availability	Show when details were confirmed and what remains uncertain.
Control over location	Manual location selection works; tracking is not required.
Flexible completion	A shorter outing can still be a completed experience.

A useful innovation test

A feature belongs in the product only if it improves discovery, decision confidence or continuity of the outing. Decorative rewards and generated recommendations will not compensate for weak venue information. The most important innovation to test is whether a story can survive real-world changes without losing its usefulness.

04 Pilot experience in Mysuru

The Morning Table

The proposed pilot trail introduces a dosa stop, a filter-coffee stop and a Mysore-pak story. The sequence is an editorial example, not a published route. Actual venues, distances, opening times, prices, accessibility and permission to feature businesses must be checked on site before launch.

The app illustration uses a 90-minute label as a design placeholder. It is not an established journey duration. A live estimate will combine verified walking time, merchant service estimates and a declared buffer. The user will see the estimate’s assumptions and can shorten the trail.

An example session

A user chooses Mysuru, enters an available morning window and a spending range, and selects a relaxed walking preference. They inspect the trail, read the stop details and save it. At the first venue, they can read the dish story and decide whether to order. The passport can record the experience without requesting a receipt.

If the coffee stop is unavailable, the user sees an explanation and available alternatives. Selecting an alternative updates the remaining estimate after confirmation. If none satisfies the constraints, the app offers a shorter plan rather than claiming that a suitable stop exists.

Stop	Experience	Verification before publication
Dosa	A short preparation story and optional tasting.	Menu, price range, hours and ingredient information.
Filter coffee	A preparation and serving story.	Service availability, milk information and seating.
Mysore pak	A sourced regional food story and optional purchase.	Recipe-specific ingredients, vendor details and provenance.

Route inspection

An operations owner will walk the candidate route at representative times, check public access and crossings, and document barriers. Illustrative maps will not be used as navigation instructions. Live directions must come from a suitable map provider and a route approved for the pilot.

05 Interface and visual design



Illustrated interface direction showing discovery, a trail and the food passport

The visual language uses warm ivory, deep aubergine, turmeric and restrained terracotta. Regional illustrations provide character; practical information uses clear, compact typography. The artwork is a direction study. Production layouts require measured contrast, scalable text, tested touch targets and accessible navigation.

Screen	Essential behaviour
Discover	Select a city manually, inspect themes and compare trail constraints.

Screen	Essential behaviour
Trail overview	Show stops, estimated duration, spending assumptions and freshness of details.
Stop details	Present story, venue information, dietary disclosures and available actions.
Change a stop	Explain alternatives and changes to the remaining plan before confirmation.
Passport	Separate stories read, self-reported visits and any confirmed referral record.
Support	Report incorrect details, request correction or explain an unavailable stop.

Content hierarchy

A decision screen puts practical constraints before decorative content. The next action must remain visible without requiring the user to interpret an illustration. Buttons use literal labels such as “Replace this stop”, “Continue without this stop” and “Read the story”.

06 Preferences and recommendation rules

Hard requirements and preferences

The pilot uses a small, curated candidate set rather than an opaque recommendation model. It separates hard exclusions from preferences. A user-declared exclusion removes incompatible or insufficiently documented candidates. Preferences such as pace, theme and atmosphere influence ordering only after basic eligibility checks.

Eligibility pipeline

First check publication approval and active listing status. Then evaluate the visit window, merchant confirmation freshness, travel feasibility and user exclusions. If a required detail is unknown, mark the candidate for review rather than treating missing information as a match. Rank the remaining candidates and explain the main reasons for the recommendation.

Dietary information

Venue-provided ingredients and preparation disclosures must identify their source and confirmation date. A vegetarian tag is not a statement that a dish is free from milk, nuts or cross-contact. The product must not translate a preference match into an allergen-safety guarantee. Users can contact the venue before making a purchase decision.

Group mode after the pilot

A later shared trail can combine participants’ agreed preferences without exposing private dietary details to the group. Conflicting requirements lead to a visible choice: choose another stop, split an optional activity or shorten the outing. The system cannot promise a universal match when the candidate set does not contain one.

Condition	Required response
No eligible alternative	Offer a shorter trail and reading mode.

Condition	Required response
Budget details are incomplete	Show an estimated range and missing assumptions.
Opening information is stale	Mark the listing for confirmation before inclusion.
User declines location access	Allow manual city selection and external directions.
Merchant pauses service	Remove new referrals and notify affected active plans.

07 Merchant operations and editorial trust

Merchant onboarding

The pilot operations team verifies the business identity, venue location, permission to publish supplied material, menu details and named contact. Merchants choose the hours and capacity information they can maintain. Participation does not imply endorsement by a tourism body or a claim of historical authenticity.

A small merchant console

The first console needs three primary actions: update availability, edit practical details and report a problem. Service can be paused without deleting the listing. The console displays the current public record, its last confirmation time and pending changes. Material changes require review before publication where they affect editorial or dietary claims.

Content production

Each story has an author, evidence record, editor, version and review date. Separate documented information, attributed oral history and interpretation. A local account can be interesting without being declared the definitive origin of a dish. Contributors receive agreed credit and permission terms before publication.

Corrections and disputes

Users and merchants can report inaccuracies from the affected listing. An editor triages the report, records evidence, updates or temporarily withdraws the claim and informs the reporting party where appropriate. Urgent availability issues can be paused operationally while historical disputes undergo editorial review.

Role	Accountability
Merchant contact	Confirm service information and flag unavailability.
Local operations owner	Inspect candidate stops, monitor issues and maintain the pilot.
Editor	Check sources, permissions, attribution and corrections.
Product and design lead	Prioritise evidence, define journeys and assess experience quality.
Engineering and QA	Maintain state, availability updates, recovery and instrumentation.

Commercial independence

Any sponsored placement must be identified. Payment cannot override eligibility or purchase an editorial claim. Organic recommendations and commercial attribution must remain distinguishable in both the interface and reporting.

08 Minimum viable product and requirements

The first release

Build one mobile-first web experience for one inspected neighbourhood cluster, with one published trail and a small set of verified alternatives. Include English and Kannada interface copy where reviewed translations are available. Users can browse without an account; account creation is optional for cross-device passport recovery.

ID	Requirement	Acceptance condition
F01	Inspect a trail	Stops, assumptions, confirmation dates and costs are visible before starting.
F02	Start without tracking	Manual location selection and planning work without location permission.
F03	Recover from a closure	User can replace, skip or finish early without losing progress.
F04	Read without purchase	Stories and reading progress never require a paid meal.
F05	Maintain merchant details	An authorised pause prevents new eligible referrals.
F06	Resume after connection loss	Saved content remains readable; live information is labelled unavailable.
F07	Protect private notes	Notes are private by default and excluded from merchant reports.
F08	Correct an error	Reports attach to a record and enter an owned review queue.

Deferred features

Defer meal checkout, live table inventory, loyalty currency, augmented reality, open user-generated trails, real-time group editing and automated historical content. These introduce operational or trust costs before the basic discovery experience has demonstrated value.

Scope decisions

Availability and recovery take priority over decorative animation because a closed destination can invalidate the outing. Passport artwork follows usable progress tracking. Every additional feature must identify the user problem it resolves and the evidence needed to justify its cost.

09 Technical design and data

Implementation direction

Use a responsive web application with installable offline capabilities for the pilot. A managed backend supports published content, merchant updates and user-controlled progress. The

implementation stack will be selected against team capability, deployment cost, accessibility support and operational maintainability.

Entity	Key data and responsibility
Trail version	Ordered stop options, narrative, constraints, review status and publication version.
Venue	Contact ownership, location, service details, availability and confirmation time.
Dish record	Venue-specific ingredient information, source and last confirmation.
Story version	Author, sources, attribution, permissions and editorial status.
Trail session	Selected version, stop decisions, timestamps and recovery actions.
Passport entry	Entry type, source, private note and user deletion controls.
Issue report	Affected version, category, evidence, owner and resolution history.

State and synchronisation

Trail sessions move through SAVED, ACTIVE, PAUSED and FINISHED. Individual stops can be PLANNED, SKIPPED or VISITED_SELF_REPORTED. Reading progress is independent. Offline actions receive a unique identifier; synchronisation must not duplicate passport entries. Server validation governs any future merchant-confirmed referral state.

Offline behaviour

A downloaded trail includes text, approved illustrations and the saved practical snapshot. Display its download time. Opening hours and availability are never presented as live while offline. The user can continue reading and record a local note; refreshed information is reconciled after reconnection.

Privacy and access

Store only data needed for the declared feature. Background movement tracking is outside the pilot. Restrict merchant access to their own listings and aggregate reporting. Establish retention, deletion, backup and incident procedures before public release. Applicable privacy obligations require implementation review rather than an assumption that this specification establishes compliance.

10 Research and product validation

Discovery before route publication

Plan eight qualitative interviews with prospective explorers and five merchant interviews. Recruit different familiarity levels and operating models. Ask participants to reconstruct a recent outing, explain how they chose venues, describe failures and identify information they did not trust. Ask merchants about service interruptions, group arrivals and their ability to maintain updates.

These are planned sample sizes, not completed research. The work can expose themes and operational constraints; it cannot establish city-wide demand. Separate observation, quotation, interpretation and product decision in the research record.

Formative usability

Run an initial five-person prototype round. Ask participants to choose a trail within a stated time window, explain the spending estimate, handle a closed stop and find ingredient information. Include a task with location permission declined. Observe behaviour before explaining how the product works.

Hypothesis	Evidence	Initial revision trigger
Planning is understandable	Participant explains time and budget assumptions.	Repeated material misunderstanding in two of five sessions.
Recovery preserves the outing	Participant replaces or skips without losing progress.	Any blocking failure; repeated uncertainty about the result.
Food information is interpreted correctly	Participant distinguishes preference tags from safety assurance.	Any credible misunderstanding prompts wording review.
Merchants can maintain the service	Observed pause and update tasks.	Updates require repeated staff assistance.

Concierge pilot

Before investing in automated routing, run a small staff-supported pilot with approximately twenty consenting adults across scheduled outing windows. Check the same practical information manually, record every intervention and interview users afterward. A strong result must reflect user value and a sustainable workload, not success achieved through invisible staff effort.

11 Measurement and commercial plan

The primary outcome

Useful outing rate is the proportion of started trail sessions whose users report that the experience helped them complete or intentionally shorten the outing. Report response coverage alongside the rate; non-response cannot be treated as satisfaction. Pair this with observed recovery success and operational workload.

Measure	Definition
Activation	Sessions starting a trail divided by eligible trail-detail sessions in the same cohort.
Recovery success	Disrupted sessions reaching a confirmed replacement, skip or early finish.
Information reliability	Inspected stop records without material errors divided by inspected records.
Merchant burden	Recorded staff minutes per active merchant per week.

Measure	Definition
Story engagement	Distinct stories deliberately opened, separate from purchases and visits.
Repeat use	Consenting pilot users starting another outing within a declared follow-up window.

Pilot decision gates

Initially require no unresolved blocker in start, recovery or progress saving; no unresolved serious misrepresentation of food information; and at least fifteen of twenty planned pilot participants providing outcome feedback. For that pilot, twelve reporting a useful outing is a provisional internal continuation signal, not statistical proof of demand. Review negative cases and merchant workload before expanding.

Revenue hypothesis

Keep discovery and basic stories free during validation. Test a paid premium trail pack containing additional curated audio and editorial material. Users still pay venues directly. Later, an optional merchant referral agreement can be considered only if attribution and incremental value are demonstrable. Do not charge on self-reported visits.

Illustrative unit economics

Assume a trail pack price of INR 199 and combined variable payment, content royalty and support costs of INR 59. Contribution is INR 140 before acquisition and fixed costs. With assumed acquisition cost of INR 60 per paid purchase, remaining contribution is INR 80. At INR 80, recovering INR 2,40,000 of fixed pilot costs requires 3,000 paid purchases. These are planning assumptions, not a forecast or validated price; actual taxes, fees and costs must be modelled before selling.

12 Delivery roadmap and launch operations

Gate	Evidence required	Decision
Discovery	User and merchant interviews; current alternatives reviewed.	Continue, revise audience or stop.
Content readiness	Permissions, sources and venue facts reviewed.	Approve a candidate trail.
Route readiness	On-site inspection and tested fallback stops.	Approve controlled pilot access.
Prototype validation	Critical planning and recovery tasks tested.	Resolve blockers before build expansion.
Concierge pilot	Outcome feedback, intervention log and cost record.	Assess value and operating effort.
Public pilot	Reliable updates, support ownership and release checks.	Expand only after evidence review.

Operational rhythm

Before each pilot window, the operations owner confirms active venue details and reviews unresolved reports. During the window, a named person monitors closures and support. Afterward, reconcile incidents, update content and review whether the route remains publishable. A merchant who cannot maintain updates should not be silently treated as live.

Go to market

Recruit the first participants through agreed local community, accommodation and food-business partnerships. Test messages about cultural discovery and easy planning separately. Track acquisition source and conversion without presenting partner names or endorsements before agreement. Discount-led growth will not be used to conceal weak interest in the experience itself.

Launch conditions

Release only after venue permission, route checks, content sourcing, translations, accessibility testing, privacy disclosures, support ownership, error monitoring and recovery behaviour are ready. If a route loses enough eligible stops to meet its promise, pause new starts and provide affected users a clear alternative.

Team ownership

I own product direction, research synthesis, prioritisation, journeys, interface requirements and decision gates. An editor owns source review; local operations owns route reliability; merchant contacts own supplied updates; engineering and QA own implementation quality. Staffing and dates follow confirmed capacity and measured pilot effort.

13 Risks and first execution backlog

Risk	Response
A destination is closed	Confirm availability, offer eligible alternatives and support early finish.
Food claims are misunderstood	Use venue-specific disclosures, clear uncertainty and editorial review.
Stories flatten local culture	Credit contributors, distinguish oral history and support corrections.
Merchant work becomes excessive	Measure effort and simplify the console before expanding.
Routes do not fit users	Validate on site and expose travel, timing and access assumptions.
Rewards encourage unwanted purchases	Separate reading and visits; remove purchase streaks and volume targets.
Commercial incentives distort recommendations	Disclose sponsorship and preserve eligibility rules.

The next work to execute

First, prepare interview screening and consent. Second, shortlist a candidate Mysuru cluster and obtain venue interest without claiming participation. Third, inspect the route and document fallback options. Fourth, assemble one sourced story and its permission record. Fifth, prototype planning, closure recovery and the passport. Sixth, test those flows before building the full pilot.

Definition of done for the pilot build

The pilot build is ready when a user can start without location permission, inspect the complete plan, read without buying, recover from a closure, retain progress after reconnection and report an error. Merchants can pause their listings. Editors can withdraw unsupported content. Each critical requirement has a passing test and an accountable owner.

The product decision that follows

Expand only if the outing provides value beyond a saved list of places and the team can maintain its practical details at a viable cost. FLAVOUR QUEST should make a city easier to explore and its food stories easier to understand. Its creative identity must be supported by dependable operations.

14 References and evidence register

References below support limited contextual statements. They do not establish demand, merchant participation, route suitability or financial performance for FLAVOUR QUEST. Accessed 15 October 2026.

[1] Swiggy Limited. Annual Report FY 2024–25. Out-of-Home Consumption discussion. https://www.swiggy.com/corporate/wp-content/uploads/2025/07/Swiggy-Annual-Report-FY-2024-25.pdf

[2] Karnataka Tourism. Mysore Pak. https://karnatakatourism.org/en/experiences/mysore-pak

Evidence item	Current status	Required next step
Customer problem	Hypothesis.	Complete discovery interviews and synthesis.
Merchant participation	Not agreed.	Obtain consent and verify operating details.
Pilot route	Illustrative sequence.	Inspect actual streets, venues and alternatives.
Historical stories	Editorial work pending.	Source, attribute and review each claim.
Usability outcomes	Not measured.	Run prototype sessions and record findings.
Price and economics	Illustrative assumptions.	Test willingness to pay and obtain actual costs.
Visuals	Original concept illustrations.	Translate into tested production layouts.